The issue here is the threat that was overlooked, which thereby created a window of vulnerability. There is another lesson, too, from Ravana's behavioural characteristics and that, paradoxically, is the attitude of those who feel wronged by history. He is badgered by his advisers to regain their dominant status in Lanka, a land that was once ruled by his maternal grandfather Sumali. Ravana consequently begins by displacing his elder brother Kuber, who comes from a different stock. But it then becomes an endless quest, powered by a sense of entitlement and absence of restraint. There are important learnings here for entrenched and rising powers alike, both in charting a path and in managing their ambitions. Total security will always be a fruitless quest.

A different example presents itself much earlier in the epic, when Bharata and accompanying sages try to persuade Rama to return to Ayodhya after the death of King Dasaratha. The sage Jabali makes a particularly impassioned appeal, underlining that the promise that Rama made to his father was no longer binding after the latter's demise. This provokes Rama's anger and he questions how trust would be maintained if vows were so lightly discarded. The sages appreciate his stance while confessing that they had to make their best effort to bring him back. The point eventually is about credibility, not just as a personal virtue but as a larger systemic underpinning. If states do not honour agreements and adhere to obligations, they must weigh any tactical gains against the larger damage that they have done to their reputation.

## A MULTIDIMENSIONAL CHALLENGE

The Galwan clash between China and India in June 2020 saw the first fatalities on their border in 45 years. It was not just the underpinning of peace and tranquillity that was shattered as a result. Working assumptions about their relationship built up over four decades were now suddenly questionable. China's disregard for established agreements, which led to this turn of events, also has its own further implications. But even as India gears up to take on a new level of concerns on its northern borders, there are cascading questions posed by China's posture. Together, these immediate developments and long-term concerns create a multidimensional challenge to Indian foreign policy.

Among the many issues that India has to address in its endeavour to ascend in the world order, the relationship with China undoubtedly presents the most complex problem. On the one hand, the parallel but differential rise of the two polities constitutes the core of global re-balancing. Willy-nilly, the two countries have ended up creating greater space in the international architecture. Together, they are drivers of what was touted in more optimistic days as heralding an 'Asian century'. At one time, there was even talk of concluding a bilateral FTA, a discussion that was set to rest